of the BSF and ICG, and I took the opportunity to familiarize myself with their roles and tasks. I also took a ride in an Air Cushion Vehicle aka Hovercraft.

The Captain of the hovercraft was of the rank of Cdr (Lt Col), and his number 2-cum-XO equivalent was a woman officer of the rank of Lt Cdr (Maj). While the Captain was piloting the craft, it was the XO who was passing all the orders to the crew. There were just no issues with respect to the men taking orders from a woman and of just one woman in a boatload of men. Moreover, she was the only woman officer at this most isolated of locations. I have yet failed to understand why in the Army we make such a fuss about such issues, forcing the courts to intervene. Are we still too feudal and paternal? We have to change with the times, otherwise, change will be forced upon us, and that is exactly what happened with respect to granting permanent commission to women officers.

Tanot was a trip down memory lane as I had last been here as a 2/Lt, when the unit was at Bikaner and the Bn Node at Tanot was our responsibility. Of course, a lot had changed—Tanot itself from a nondescript man-and-a-camel village to a bustling township. The dunes were the same, maybe a bit more scrub and sprinkling of kikar trees but it brought back fond memories. I did note, though, that the extent of the Node seemed to have grown from what I could remember. There is always a tendency to go for (occupy) the next dune and the next and the next, and before one realizes it, Companies and Platoons get overstretched, leaving wide gaps in between that are covered neither by observation nor fire, allowing the enemy to exploit these gaps and attack each locality piecemeal, since they are not in mutual support of each other. Lessons learnt over forty years ago were still fresh in my mind. Perhaps too, there was a need to review our plans and base the defences not

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation